



Thousands gather during the Velvet Revolution in Czechoslovakia, a bloodless uprising that saw the overthrow of the communist government on December 29.

IN SOUTH AFRICA, F.W. DE KLERK (B. 1936) WAS ELECTED LEADER of the **National Party** on February 2. The party had governed the country since 1948 on the principle of **apartheid**. However, De Klerk was more willing than his predecessors to modernize the political system. On August 15, the incumbent president, P.W. Botha (1916–2006) suffered a stroke and **De Klerk took over**. Klerk began **releasing prominent black leaders** who had been imprisoned, including Walter Sisulu, a close friend of Nelson Mandela (b. 1918), one of the the leaders of the African National Congress (ANC).

On February 14, **Ayatollah Khomeini** (1902–89), the spiritual leader of Iran, issued a *fatwa*, or decree, calling for the death of author **Salman Rushdie** (b. 1947) and the publishers of his book, *The Satanic Verses*. The book was considered to be a **blasphemy against Islam**. Rushdie was forced into hiding, under armed guard, to protect his life (see 1998).

Later in the year, on June 3, **Khomeini died** in Tehran. His death was **mourned by millions**. Eight people were killed in the stampede and hundreds more injured while approaching the body to pay obeisance. The incumbent president, Ali Khamenei became Supreme Leader of Iran.

Vietnam promised to withdraw its troops from Cambodia by the end of September, a decade after invading the country (see 1979). In a declaration made on April 5, Vietnam also urged the world to ensure that the **Cambodian civil**



war was truly over and that Khmer Rouge leader **Pol Pot** (see 1973) would never be allowed to return to power again.

In China, a **demonstration** held in **Tiananmen Square**, Beijing, ended in **bloodshed** on June 4, after civilians were killed by the People's Liberation Army. Tanks were lined up in the streets to confront protestors, mainly students, who had been stationed there for seven weeks. The crowds, which swelled to more than 100,000, called for economic and political reform in the country.

Almost a decade after they had stormed the country, **Soviet troops withdrew** from Afghanistan in February. They left the economy in ruins. Many Afghans had fled,

Making a stand

The figure of a lone man in front of army tanks in Tiananmen Square, China, became a poignant symbol of the protests.

and **civil war continued** as the Mujahideen (Persian for "warriors") pushed to overthrow President Najibullah's Soviet-backed government (see 1992).

On April 17, **Solidarity**, Poland's free trade union movement, was **legalized** after a ban of seven years. It grew into a political movement, and in elections held on June 5, **Solidarity won** an overwhelming majority. After 45 years, **communist rule in Poland ended**. Solidarity formed a new noncommunist government in the former Eastern Bloc. On

100,000
PROTEST

3,000 killed

Tiananmen Square massacre

The Chinese Army shot dead nearly 3,000 of the 100,000 demonstrators who protested in Tiananmen Square in Beijing.

September 12, Tadeusz Mazowiecki became prime minister.

By the start of 1989, communist regimes had ruled Eastern Europe for 45 years. By the end of the year they had all been routed by extraordinary **public uprisings**. Following the election of Solidarity in Poland, Hungary's rulers published a **plan for independence**. A **coup in Bulgaria** brought down party leader Todor Zhivkov. On

November 28, the **Czechoslovak communist regime surrendered** to the people. A month later, Václav Havel became President of the Czechoslovak Republic in the nonviolent **Velvet Revolution**. In Romania, the incumbent president, **Nicolae Ceausescu** was removed from office and **shot** in December.

Erich Honecker, leader of the German Democratic Republic, entered 1989 confident that the reforms in neighboring countries would not affect his country, but protests grew. The Hungarian government demolished the electric fence along the Austrian frontier, part of the **Iron Curtain**—the heavily guarded border between the countries of the Eastern Bloc and the rest of Europe. By September, when the **border controls were lifted**, 60,000 East Germans were in Hungary waiting to pour through to the West. On October 2, a **huge protest calling for reform** gathered in Leipzig, and decided

COLD WAR ESPIONAGE

Espionage epitomized the Cold War. Intelligence gathered by electronic devices, satellites, and spies was used for military information and technology. The US Central Intelligence Agency (CIA), the Soviet KGB, and East German secret police, or *Stasi* (see badge, right), spent decades spying on the enemy and undermining rivals through covert action.

